Credo

By Craig Lucas

INTRODUCTION

It used to be all the rage to write a "personal creed." When "honor" wasn't looked at as something to avoid, "compassion" wasn't an indication of weakness, and "armed forces" weren't something to avoid at all costs, men and women took the time to figure out what make themselves tick. Determining what you believe, what you value, and where you want to place your time and effort can give you a certainty about your life like nothing else can. Determining what you're all about...your mission statement, if you will...makes it so you know in advance what you will and won't do in life. What's your Credo by Craig Lucas.

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It's Christmas eve,

I go out with the dog.

Jim and I have just broken up.

I've just been to an AA meeting

Where a woman got up

And said she had no friends,

Her best friend is her VCR

And it's broken.

I came home to the hole where the sofa was.

There's no Christmas tree either.

I can't stand the thought of sweeping up all the dead needles

And dragging the carcass out to the street

To join all the other dead trees

With what's happening to the rain forest.

I know the two aren't connected,

But anyway, I pull up a folding chair

And heat up a piece of cold pizza.

This, I think, is the low point.

The walls show little ghosts where the pictures once were.

I go out.

Did I tell you I didn't get my Christmas bonus?

Well, I wasn't expecting it,

But I haven't been able to take Apple to the vet about her problem,

So she dribbles a little across the lobby,

Past the doorman who isn't smiling at me;

I'm sure it's because I haven't given him *his* Christmas bonus,

But maybe's it's the trail of urine, too,

I don't stop to ask.

I smile bravely

And step outside where it has of course started to rain. .

And people are running and looking very upset.

Surely the rain isn't that bad.

I turn

There's been an accident on my corner

I snap my head away,

I know if I look there'll be a baby carriage there

In the middle of the street.

I refuse to look.

They certainly don't need another person standing around not doing anything.

I put my mind ... Where can I put my mind?

Vienna.

Where Jim has gone with the woman he left me for.

You can't escape these thoughts.

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All I know is her name.

Her name ... is Carmella.

Apparently.

And I believe that she has had a sex change.

As far as I know, this has no basis in fact,

But I believe it as firmly as-I believe

That there is nothing wrong with New York City

That can't be solved at least in part by keeping

Cardinal John J. O'Connor out of city politics

And back doing what he really does best

Which, if we are to take his word for it, is:

Exorcisms.

Where,

Where can I put my thoughts?

Ecuador.

My parents are in Ecuador.

They asked me to join them,

And I said

No, Jim and I would be spending the holiday together.

I hope that he and Carmella are caught

In the crossfire of some terrorist ...

No, I don't .

Not really. But you know:

The sort of thing you see

On the evening news.

If you have a TV

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Or a phone.

Jim stopped paying the bills months ago,

As a kind of secret warning of what was to come.

But I refuse,

In my bones I refuse

To see myself as a victim.

I have gotten myself into this.

I allowed him to talk me into maintaining a joint bank account.

Every time a little voice in my head would say

Watch out.

He's cute,

But he's not that nice.

Beneath it all,

Behind the charm,

His chin,

That first night,

And then again in Barbados,

Beneath it all

Is *him.*

I alone took each and every step

Which brought me here

To this street corner

In the rain

On Christmas eve

With my dog whose urinary infection

I cannot afford to fix.

And at that moment, my friends,

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My dog squats.

And the worst thing that has ever happened to me

Unfolds before my very eyes.

A wire, loose plug from somebody's Christmas decorations

Carelessly strung in front of their little tea shop ...

Electrocutes my dog.

And she falls immediately dead

On the sidewalk

In a sputter of sparks ...

And the lights go out all down the front of the tea shop.

And a man comes out:

"What did you do?"

And I drop to my knees, unafraid,

Let me die, too,

Electrocute me.

And I embrace my dog, Apple,

Whom I have had for sixteen years.

She is my oldest friend.

She has seen me in my darkest, most drunken days.

She has been to every corner of my life,

She growled at the dogs on the dog food commercials.

She has been across the country and back.

Apple, I'm not afraid to say, is the purest,

Most uncomplicated expression of love I have ever known.

And she has been killed by an electric current

In the last sick days of her valiant existence.

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The man stares at me from above.

"Oh my god" he says.

He can't believe it

Any more than I can believe it.

Come in, he says.

We carry Apple into the shop.

To me she smells good,

But to some people she does not.

It's been too cold to bathe her.

It's hard for one person to hold her in the shower.

She doesn't like the water.

The man offers me the only thing he has.

Tea.

We talk

And he assures me that the accident on the corner

Did *not* involve a child.

And no one was killed.

What to do now with Apple?

I can't cry anymore.

I have cried so much the last two weeks

I can't cry for her now.

And I know ...

In some way I see all at once that

Jim was not really good enough for me,

That I will meet someone else.

And even if I don't I will have

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An extraordinary and rich and complicated life.

It is entirely up to me.

I will most likely survive all the roadblocks and the detours.

As my dad always says:

"Life can be rough, but think about the alternative."

But then again

He's never been sick a day in his life.

He hasn't ever had to struggle just to stand

Or been unable to stop himself from peeing

Where he knows he shouldn't

And doesn't want to,

But there it is in a stream,

Surprising him and me.

He's never had to look up

With big sorrowful eyes which say:

"I had no idea.

Don't yell."

No.

I only hope that 1 will go as quickly as Apple

When the time comes.

And if I don't,

I will absolutely,

I *know* I will face that bravely

And with dignity.

I know.

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And if,

For some unforeseen but totally justified reason,

I can't,

And I am making a complete ass of myself,

Saying things I wouldn't ever say

And acting childishly

And turning into a prude

And a conservative

And am being a complete drag on everyone

For months and years,

I know my friends will forgive me.

And if for some equally valid and twisted,

But ultimately logical reason,

They don't

Or they can't,

Or they're all dead by then,

Or it's August and they're away

Then I will forgive them,

Right?

The same way I forgave myself

For yelling at Apple the first time she peed

Before I realized what was going on.

And if. ..

Again, if I can't,

And everything is entirely for shit

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And I can't even find my way to the end of a sentence ...

And ... you can fill in all the blanks ...

That will be fine, too.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier – Poetry – Female
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